

Verbal Reasoning

Placement Training Program

Reading Comprehension

Reading comprehension tests both understanding and speed simultaneously. A reliable approach: skim the passage first for overall structure and main idea rather than reading every word closely on the first pass, then read the questions, then return to the specific parts of the passage relevant to each question for a closer read. Answers to 'inference' questions (as opposed to direct fact-lookup questions) must be supportable by what's actually stated in the passage — not by outside knowledge or what seems generally reasonable, a distinction that trips up strong readers who over-rely on background knowledge.

Sentence Correction

Sentence correction questions test grammar rules applied to real sentences: subject-verb agreement (a singular subject takes a singular verb, even when other plural nouns appear nearby and create a false sense of a plural subject), consistent tense within a sentence, correct use of prepositions, and parallel structure in lists ('she likes reading, writing, and to swim' breaks parallelism — it should be 'reading, writing, and swimming'). Reading the corrected sentence back in full, not just the changed portion, catches errors introduced by a fix that solves one problem while breaking something else in the sentence.

Vocabulary

Vocabulary questions (synonyms, antonyms, fill-in-the-blank word choice) reward both direct knowledge and the ability to infer a word's meaning from context and word roots when it's unfamiliar. Recognizing common prefixes/suffixes (like 'bene-' meaning good, '-phobia' meaning fear) can narrow down an unfamiliar word's general meaning even without having seen that exact word before — a genuinely useful technique on test day when a completely unfamiliar word appears.

Critical Reasoning

Critical reasoning questions present a short argument and ask you to identify its underlying assumption, what would strengthen or weaken it, or a logical flaw in its reasoning. The core skill is separating the argument's actual logical structure (premise ! conclusion) from the surface topic — two arguments about completely different subjects can share the identical underlying flawed logical structure, and recognizing that structure is what these questions are really testing, not subject-matter knowledge.

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